C8W5 · TUESDAY, FEBRUARY 17, 2026

INTERVIEW SYNTHESIS & COMMITMENT

From Messy Interviews to Clear Direction

PART 1: WHY SYNTHESIS MATTERS

NOW WHAT DO I DO WITH ALL OF THIS (POSSIBLY CONFLICTING) INFORMATION?

THE CONFIRMATION BIAS TRAP

Interviews are **messy**. People contradict themselves. Different people want different things. Some people are polite when they should be blunt.

The natural response?

- Pick the quotes that **confirm** what you already believed
- Ignore the rest
- Declare victory

⚠️ That's not synthesis. That's **confirmation bias**.

IF YOUR IDEA SOUNDS EXACTLY THE SAME AS BEFORE YOU DID INTERVIEWS, ONE OF TWO THINGS HAPPENED.

Either your original hypothesis was perfect — which is extremely rare — or you didn't synthesize well.

THE SYNTHESIS PROCESS

1. READ ACROSS, NOT WITHIN

Don't summarize each interview separately. Look for what comes up **across** conversations.

2. WEIGHT INTENSITY, NOT JUST FREQUENCY

"1 person got visibly upset" > "3 people mentioned it." **Frequency = common. Intensity = painful.**

3. HUNT FOR CONTRADICTIONS

When two people disagree, don't pick a winner. Ask: **why might they see it differently?**

4. SEPARATE "NICE" FROM "NEED"

Look for problems they've **already tried to solve**, already spent money on, already changed behavior around.

THE SYNTHESIS PROCESS (CONT.)

5. NOTICE WHAT SURPRISED YOU

If everything confirms your hypothesis, you're probably **cherry-picking**. The most valuable findings are the ones you didn't expect.

6. USE THEIR LANGUAGE, NOT YOURS

If your synthesis says "streamlined experience" or "value proposition," you've **lost the signal**. Keep their actual words.

💡 **Method:** This is a simplified version of *thematic analysis* (Braun & Clarke, 2006) — the gold standard for qualitative synthesis. Read all notes first, code observations, cluster into themes, check themes against raw data.

COMMON FAILURE MODES

CONFIRMATION BIAS

Remembering quotes that support your idea, forgetting the lukewarm ones

PREMATURE CONVERGENCE

Settling on themes before reading all data. Relabeling interview questions as "findings"

CHERRY-PICKING QUOTES

3 enthusiastic quotes, zero skeptical ones. Report the full range.

ANCHORING TO EARLY INTERVIEWS

First 2-3 interviews become the lens for everything else

CLEANING UP TOO EARLY

Resolving contradictions by picking the majority view instead of sitting with the tension

FOUNDER BIAS

Emotional investment in the outcome amplifies every other bias on this list

THE LLM SYNTHESIS DEBATE

SHOULD YOU USE AI TO SYNTHESIZE?

WHAT LLMS ARE GOOD AT

- Finding **patterns** across many documents quickly
- Identifying themes you might **miss** because you're too close
- **Consistency:** applies the same lens to every interview
- Organizing unstructured notes into **categories**

WHAT LLMS ARE BAD AT

- Can't know someone **teared up** or was being polite
- **Flattens nuance:** the weird outlier gets averaged away
- **Imposes patterns:** finds themes whether or not they're real
- Produces **confident synthesis** even when data is messy

THE NUMBERS

80%

OF UX RESEARCHERS USE AI

Up 24 points from 2024

41%

VIEW AI'S EFFECT NEGATIVELY

vs. only 32% positively

78-96%

AGREEMENT WITH HUMAN CODERS

But flattens nuance at every level

⚠️ LLMs classify **divergent themes as convergent**. If half your interviewees love a feature and half hate it, the LLM synthesis says "users generally find it acceptable."

AI CAN PROCESS DATA FASTER THAN YOU. BUT YOU WERE IN THE ROOM.

You saw the body language. You felt the energy shift. That context matters.

THE BALANCED APPROACH

1

DO YOUR OWN SYNTHESIS FIRST

Develop your read on the data before seeing what the AI thinks

2

THEN ASK THE AI

Feed your notes into an LLM and ask it to synthesize independently

3

COMPARE

Not "which is right?" but "what did it find that I missed, and what did I notice that it didn't?"

💡 This is the same mindset you'll need for synthetic user testing on Thursday. **AI generates hypotheses. Humans validate them.**

PART 2: APPLY THE FRAMEWORK

TASK 1: SYNTHESIZE YOUR INTERVIEWS

📋 **How to do this:** Open FigJam. Everyone reads through the interview notes **on your own devices**. Write out what stands out: pain points, user insights, persona clues, key quotes. Then cluster together as a team.

1. PATTERNS

What came up in **3+ interviews**? List recurring themes — be specific, not vague.

2. STRONGEST QUOTES

Pull the **3-5 most vivid, emotional, or specific quotes**. These are your copy raw material.

3. CONTRADICTIONS

Where did interviewees **disagree**? What might explain the difference?

4. SURPRISES

What did you learn that you **didn't expect**? What changed your thinking?

5. Signal Strength: How validated does this idea feel? Strong · Moderate · Weak · Mixed

TASK 2: COMMIT TO ONE IDEA

You went into interviews with **two ideas**. Based on your synthesis, which one had stronger signal?

DECISION FRAMEWORK

- Which had more **emotional intensity**?
- Which did people describe in more **specific, vivid language**?
- Which had stronger **current-solution** evidence?
- Which generated a more **genuine reaction** to your pitch?
- Which does the team have more **energy** for?

IF YOU'RE STUCK

Go with the one where interviews **surprised you most**.
Surprises mean you're learning something new — and that's where the opportunity usually is.
You're not married to this forever. But you need to pick one to move forward.

TASK 3: PREPARE TO SHARE

Each team, prep a **30-second answer** to this question:

"What's the most surprising thing you found in your interviews?"

Not the most confirming. The most surprising.

PART 3: SHARE-OUT

WHAT TO LISTEN FOR

As each team shares, I'm listening for:

GOOD SIGNS

- Idea **evolved** from interviews
- Using **interviewee language**, not founder-speak
- Found **contradictions** and sat with them
- Can name specific **surprises**

RED FLAGS

- Idea is **unchanged** from before interviews
- All quotes **confirm** original thesis
- "No contradictions" in the data
- Language is **generic/abstract**

💡 Contradictions aren't failure — they're **information**. They often mean you're talking to two different audience segments.

PART 4: THE PIPELINE

WHERE THIS IS ALL GOING

1

SYNTHESIS

Find patterns across your ~10 interviews · Today + homework

2

PRODUCT BRIEF

One-page: what are you building, for whom, what problem · Homework

3

BRAND POSITION

Internal doc: your thesis, identity, canonical language · Homework

4

LANDING PAGE COPY

Headlines, value props, features — in user language · After brand position

5

SYNTHETIC TESTING

AI personas test your copy, find weak spots, iterate · Weekend

6

DEPLOY LANDING PAGE

Real page, live URL, ready for traffic · Due Tue Feb 24

SAY → DO

LAST WEEK

"Say" Evidence

What people *told you* in interviews

Valuable, but people are polite

THIS WEEK → NEXT

"Do" Evidence

Will strangers *click, sign up, take action*?

Landing page = first "Do" test

🎯 The synthetic test is your **preflight check** before you put something live in front of the world.

HOMEWORK: DUE THURSDAY

1. SYNTHESIS COMPARISON EXERCISE

Part A: Human Synthesis

- Key patterns across interviews
- Top 5 quotes (exact words)
- Contradictions and what they mean
- Surprises — what changed your thinking
- Your overall read on the data

Part B: AI Synthesis

Feed your snapshots **and** raw interview notes into an LLM. Capture its full output.

Part C: Comparison Reflection (1-2 paragraphs)

What did AI find that you missed? What did you notice that it didn't?

2. PRODUCT BRIEF + BRAND POSITION

Product Brief: One-page — what are you building, who is it for, what problem does it solve?

Brand Position: Internal doc — your thesis, identity, canonical language for your product.

Templates provided. Use AI to help draft these — they build directly on your synthesis.

⚠️ Do Part A **before** Part B. Develop your own read before seeing the AI's.

THURSDAY PREVIEW

DISCUSS COMPARISONS

What did you learn from comparing your synthesis to the AI's?

REVIEW BRAND POSITIONS

Discuss your brand position docs and refine together

SYNTHETIC TESTING DEMO

See the AI testing skill in action with real copy

Landing pages due next Tuesday (Feb 24) — real, deployed, live URL.

QUESTIONS?

END OF CLASS 8

Next: Brand Position + Synthetic Testing